



Arab Student Association Leadership

BYU Conservatives [REDACTED]

Sun, Oct 29, 2023 at 6:51 PM

To: sclcenter@byu.edu, byuarabsa@gmail.com

Cc: [REDACTED] <Uc-office@byu.edu>, Dureceptionist@byu.edu, [REDACTED]

Hello BYUSA and Arab Student Association,

Today the Cougar Chronicle would like to request comment on a report that we have looked over the past week or so. We have seen posts and actions taken by leaders of the club at the Arab Student Association (ASA) about their views of the Israeli and Palestinian conflict that have been concerning. While we believe the members of the ASA are free to express their opinions, we would like to make you aware of materials we have gathered in our report.

On October 7th, the day that Hamas attacked Israel with the largest terror attack the world has seen since 9/11, the President of the ASA, Sama Salah, made several posts and shared messages across her instagram story. Make note that these were the day of Oct. 7 after the Hamas attack which included the rape of women, parading dead bodies of women in the back of trucks, gunned down concert attendees, slaughtered children, and other heinous actions. These acts had been reported and were in the news on October 7th. Many were videos taken and released by Hamas itself.

Here are some quotes from those posts which can be found in a screen recording of Salah's story highlights below. She is also a co-founder of the club with her sister, Noreen Salah:

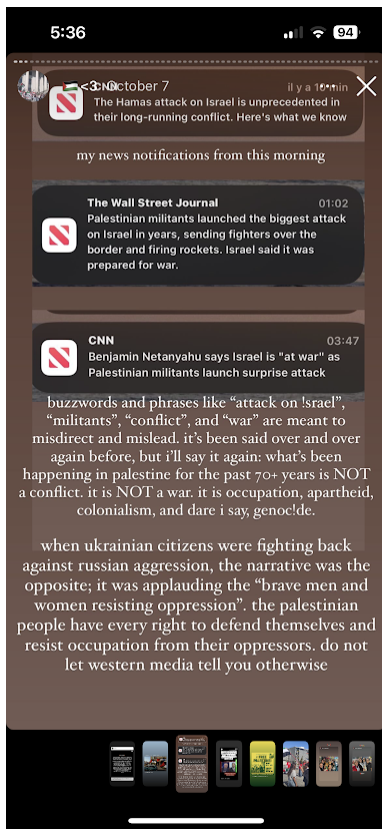
First post:

- (With a picture of palestinian flags waving) "It's free palestine until palestine is free"



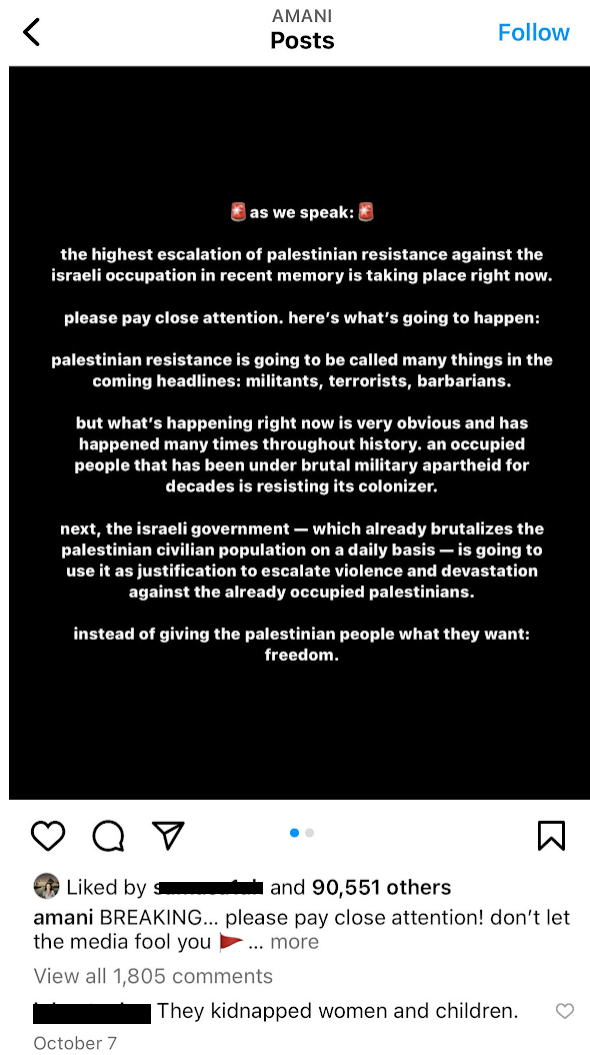
Next post with media headlines from CNN and the WSJ:

- "buzzwords and phrases like 'attack on Israel', 'militants', 'conflict', and 'war', are meant to misdirect and mislead."
- "what's been happening in palestine for the past 70+ years is NOT a conflict. it is NOT a war. it is occupation, apartheid, colonialism, and dare i say, genocide."
- "the palestinian people have every right to defend themselves and resist occupation from their oppressors. do not let western media tell you otherwise."



The next section are posts that Salah shared on Oct. 7th (not her own words):

Post from the account @amani at this link: <https://www.instagram.com/p/CyGDC2HKdoM/?igshid=MzRIODBiNWFIZA==>



Take note that Salah shared this on her story and also liked the post as noted by her username: [redacted]

This next post is calling for an emergency protest in Salt Lake in favor of Palestine. See it at this link: <https://www.instagram.com/p/CyHQqKFuWbH/>

The caption can be seen below - she shared this on Oct. 7th right after Hamas attacked Israel. This organization characterizes this attack on Israel as a "historic new counteroffensive" and emphasizes, "Long live the resistance!" and a chant that suggests the annihilation of Israel, "From the river to the sea, Palestine will be free!" This is [antisemitic](#), according to the ADL.



Salah was then at a pro-Palestinian protest on October 8th - the video of the protest was then posted on Oct. 10th at this link here: <https://www.instagram.com/p/CyOw0cwyoIU/>

Salah is the person holding a sign that says: "It's free Palestine until it's free."

Separately, on Oct. 25, the Cougar Chronicle received a tip from a student [REDACTED]. He claimed to have the following experience with other members of the ASA leadership:

He was walking on campus and overheard a conversation among some Muslim students and walked up to them as they were discussing the Israeli and Palestinian war. The following allegedly occurred:

- One student said that all Israelis want to kill all Palestinians
- The students shifted the conversation when he asked them if the students would condemn Hamas and they allegedly said that it was not relevant

He identified two other students from the ASA leadership in the conversation: [REDACTED]

In addition to all of this, the ASA, while tabling that same day, displayed the well-known false map of Palestinian territory progressing from the mid 20th century until now. Here is a photo on their instagram story from Wednesday the 25th:



The map displayed on the table can be found featured in all of these stories as false, fake, and propagandistic.

- <https://thefederalist.com/2021/05/28/new-york-times-defends-fake-anti-israel-map-of-palestine-as-art/>
- <https://www.economist.com/democracy-in-america/2010/03/14/this-map-is-not-the-territories>
- <https://honestreporting.com/misleading-palestinian-maps-twist-the-truth/>
- <https://www.thetower.org/article/the-mendacious-maps-of-palestinian-loss/>
- <https://www.thedailybeast.com/vancouvers-disappearing-palestine-transit-ads-revisited>
- <https://aijac.org.au/fresh-air/disappearing-palestine-the-maps-that-lie/>
- <https://jewishjournal.com/commentary/blogs/310190/bogus-maps-to-back-a-bogus-cause-and-continued-rejection-of-peace/>
- <https://www.timesofisrael.com/msnbc-apologizes-for-completely-wrong-maps-of-israel/>

MSNBC had to [apologize](#) for using the "map" and the [NYT deputy editor](#) said the following in defense of its usage in an opinion article published by the Times, "This artwork is not meant to represent any historical boundaries and it is not meant to serve as a literal, factual map — our data graphics department would handle such maps. This was an illustration conveying a sense of shrinking space for Palestinians. It is art."

In addition, the Daily Universe published a puff piece about the ASA group on Oct. 25 which can be found at this link: <https://universe.byu.edu/2023/10/25/byu-arab-student-association-aims-to-foster-proximity-in-times-of-strife/>

The DU interviewed ASA President Sama Salah and she said this of why she founded the group, "We wanted to create a space on campus where students can come ... be a part of inclusive events and learn more about our culture."

The author of the DU article wrote, "For members of the Arab and North African communities on campus, helping broaden others' perspectives and understanding of their culture is important, especially as conflict unfolds in Israel-Palestine." The group also plans to host events such as Palestinian voices, according to the article.

All this being said, we would like to ask the following questions of BYUSA:

1. Could BYUSA generally address these statements from Salah and characterize them?
2. How inclusive is the ASA for students attending BYU who are Jewish?
3. Why is the ASA group - despite its leadership making these kinds of statements - receiving approval status from the university when other groups such as Young Americans for Freedom do not get approved?

Could the ASA student organization please answer the following:

1. Will the ASA condemn Hamas as a terrorist organization, no matter what they think of Israel being attacked or the Palestinian civilians who have been killed in Israel's response?

2. [REDACTED]
3. Will Sama Salah further explain her statements and what she meant by them or can she provide context to her opinions?
4. Some of these statements on Salah's story highlights have been removed since they were posted, why is that the case?

We would like a response from both organizations by the end of Monday, October 30th.

-The Cougar Chronicle

 [Sama Salah Oct 7-8.mov](#)